

KF29 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

We are now beginning the third quarter of the KF training cycle, and you may wish to return a gift to Karis Fellowships that represents your gratitude for what you have gained. If you have received, it is vital that you give, for it is a principle of circulation that receiving without giving will stagnate your life. If you do not circulate, you will die. Visit **Give a Gift** on the website, or you can donate financially through PayPal to finance@karisfellowships.com. Any gift at all keeps you circulating.

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

KF Confession 7 opens the door to God’s kingdom. We give a great gift to God and to our community by walking through this door.

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

The practice of meditation and mindfulness trains our minds and emotions to step back from reacting to life’s events. We practice mindfulness to break the grip of our compelling need to be right, to be comfortable, to restore our pride, and to flee from self-hate. When we commit to live in reality, we are choosing to courageously face the truth of who we are today and the truth about others. We observe ourselves and our outcomes with compassion, and we calm ourselves as we would calm a distressed child. In the calm we find a creative, positive place within, where we can connect to God and co-labor with Him to produce glorious, oriented outcomes.

This month we are practicing **Calming Breath**, which can be used to quiet a distressed body and mind. I like to use this method when I need to calm down or when lying down before sleep. I breathe and explore the tension in my body and mind. During this exercise, you will use sound to help your body release tension. Make sure that you are on mute while we practice together.

Calming Breath

1. Prepare

Assume a meditation posture. You may wish to lie down. Settle into this experience and experiment. *(Pause)* Begin with a silent prayer for peace within yourself and in your life. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. Scan for tension

As you inhale, explore your body for tension. You might start with your feet and ankles. On the exhale, try to release tension in that area. Then, as you continue to breathe, move your attention to other areas. Remember to explore your face. We often hold unconscious tension in our face, so cultivate the habit of noticing what your face is doing. We communicate a great deal through our facial expression; our faces often speak louder than our words. Relax, let go, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. Use sound

When you feel somewhat connected to your body, use the word *CALM* as a centering word. Prolong the “ahm” sound while you softly voice the word, as if you were releasing a sigh. Here is an example. *(Give one breath as an example)* Feel your body let go and relax. You might exhale using sound for one breath and then rest quietly during the next breath, or you might scan your body again and release any tension with the sound. Continue at your own pace for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

4. Use breath

When you feel ready, let go of saying the word out loud. Allow the word to flow in your mind with your breath, or whisper the word *CALM* like this. *(Demonstrate one example)* Explore a rhythm that works for you. You might whisper the word *CALM* once and then rest for two deep breaths. With your neck straight and shoulders dropped, continue to scan and release body tension. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, release the word altogether. Deeply breathe and occasionally sigh with long exhaling breaths. Continue to release any tension in your body and mind. If an issue continues to intrude, try using the **UFO Hold**. Place the palm of one hand on your forehead and the palm of your other hand on the back of your neck. Gently move your head around as you breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

5. Rest

Breathe while you rest in the stillness with a quiet mind. If you notice your mind wandering, use the word *CALM* to draw it back into stillness. Stillness is a place of rest in your mind where there are no images, no words, and no thoughts—a very attentive but still space where you simply wait. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Gently stretch, open your eyes, and re-engage with the meeting. **Calming Breath** trains your mind and body to relax on command. It is out of the calm that we find our path to orientation. Take time throughout the day to find that calm space and give God a chance to guide you.

Our hymn for this meditation is *Spirit of God, Descend upon my Heart* by George Croly, an Irish clergyman who achieved his mission through creatively dealing with limitations.

Spirit of God, descend upon my heart.
Wean it from earth; through all its pulses move.
Stoop to my weakness, mighty as Thou art,
And let me love Thee as I ought to love.¹

Take a deep breath.

I have said this before, but I would like to remind you again that as our language degrades, much of its

wealth of meaning is lost. In the past, the English language had two forms of address, the formal *you* and the intimate *thou*. So, when you hear the words *thou* or *thee* in a hymn or poem, you know that it is referring to an intimate relationship, like in a family or between lovers.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

Have you told God that you are now committed to live in reality? When I tell God things like that, I am often scared to death because I know He will take me at my word. Even so, I courageously face the fear that He will, indeed, train me and that the training will be quite uncomfortable. I am afraid that I will have to endure and grow my courage. The reward will be wisdom from above, but we often do not realize how valuable that is. God is continually working toward unveiling our dynamic, glorious, oriented True Self and obliterating our Idol Self. It is terrifying for the Idol Self to fall into the hands of the living God.²

In Psalm 23, we learned that the path of orientation will always lead us into the valley of the shadow of death, and it is natural and healthy to fear that valley. The valley is a place where we exercise our courage and learn to turn our fear into an advantage. Healthy fear motivates us to learn our lessons well. We already understand the dangers of the wisdom from below, and this healthy fear encourages us to stay connected to the wisdom from above.

Let's look at the worksheet titled **Suffering: An Opportunity to See Yourself**. I hope that you have downloaded and printed out this worksheet from the **Toolbox** page of the KF website. You can also find this worksheet under the **Meeting Guides and Teachings** for KF29.

All suffering is an invitation to develop the muscles of courage and endurance, but only strategic suffering builds those muscles in our soul. Last week we were reminded that, as the children of God, suffering is part of our birthing process. At the beginning of any new challenge, we will suffer. This suffering helps to crack the hard shell of pride so that we are free to lay aside old misoriented habits and patterns and learn healthier ways to live. We are then able to step into the next challenge on our road to the glory of God with more confidence and more joy. This process is repeated throughout our ever-developing life.

We are no longer the victims of our suffering. We are now explorers of the opportunities that God offers to teach us how to successfully engage in the reality of *what is*. The worksheet for this lesson will help you explore the potential of your suffering. Let's look at it together.

Suffering: An Opportunity to See Yourself

THE STORY

The questions in this first section help you focus your energy around the issues linked to your suffering. Don't worry if you can't figure it all out. Keep in mind that your humble intention to reorient yourself invites God to be an ally in your healing process. If you get stuck on any step, just move on to the next one.

1. Identify the source of your suffering

First, look at your story. Write down whatever or whoever seems to be the cause of your suffering. This week, my suffering was my feelings, and my story was that the ministry is getting too big for me. Years ago, when I was writing this lesson, there were only about ten members in KF. What I then thought was too big seems quite small to me now. As the ministry has expanded, my sphere of influence has increased. Out of necessity, I have courageously developed more skills and learned to manage my business while trusting others to manage theirs. My trust in God has also grown, and I rely on Him more and more to do this work through me and through KF.

2. Recognize your feelings

I have given you a list of feelings on this worksheet, but you can also glean from the lists on other worksheets or come up with your own words to describe your feelings. If you can define what you are feeling, the integration and healing process at the end of the worksheet will be more effective.

3. Scan your body

Try to scan your body. Think about the apparent cause of your suffering and notice how your body is reacting. Have you suffered in this way before?

4. Spot the pattern

Have you experienced this type of suffering before? Just answer yes or no.

5. Anniversary trauma

Sometimes our present suffering is weighted with unprocessed trauma from past experiences. If we can identify that past suffering, we might be able to understand the intensity of our present feelings. This understanding can help us calm our feelings and renew our courage to keep working toward health.

PRIDE

1. Write down how you, in your infinite wisdom, think the situation *should* or *shouldn't* be

This is just a plain statement of fact. For example, if you are suffering at work, you could write statements like these: "I shouldn't have to do this job. I should enjoy my job. I should have a different boss or co-worker. People shouldn't get in my way." In my situation, I could write, "I should feel joy and confidence in my work all of the time." I might go even further and write, "I should always be able to lead everyone into their potential." Now that is pretty crazy!

2. Recognize the judgment

Next, you will identify the judgment. In other words, what have you judged to be bad about your situation? I might judge that my feelings are bad, that my circumstances are bad, or that I am bad, ungrateful, or incompetent. Remember that it is possible to judge seemingly good things as bad.

3. Categorize your story

This step helps you identify the types of stories that you tell to explain your fear and justify your suffering. Recognizing your story in this list can sometimes be rather humbling, but humility is what we want to learn. When I experimented with this worksheet on some very willing guinea pigs, one of those brave souls underlined the whole list! Don't be discouraged if you do the same. You are revealing weaknesses that, with training, will perfect your real strengths—and that's exciting.

THE MIRROR

This section gives you an opportunity to look at yourself. These are simple yes or no questions. Perhaps you now understand that simple choices can have astonishing results. Just answer yes or no.

WISDOM FROM ABOVE

In this section of the worksheet, I refer to a passage in the letter from James, in which he contrasts the *Wisdom from Above* with the *Wisdom from Below*.

Your responses to suffering reveal the source of your wisdom, and these two lists of characteristics can help you recognize the source. If you do not see in your life the qualities that come from the *Wisdom from Above*, your thoughts and choices need to be reoriented. However, if you do recognize characteristics of the *Wisdom from Above*, be sure to give yourself credit. Those characteristics are evidence that you are making progress—you are on your way!

Cleverness in practical matters versus inner conflicts

When we demonstrate cleverness in practical matters, we use our experience, creative faculties, and KF training to manage our problems. We can then reduce and even eliminate our suffering. One KF member remarked that when they are suffering, their KF training helps them “pivot” rather than “panic”. To pivot is to creatively seek for solutions. To panic is to react in old patterns of aggression, fear, helplessness, or retreat.

If we are full of inner conflicts, we are at war with ourselves and with God. We may actually need our suffering to help us escape from reality and drive our search for glory. We are double-minded, desiring the benefits of oriented outcomes but consistently choosing thoughts and behaviors that produce misorientation. Let me give you an example. I know that my thoughts and behavior are destructive, but I have an inviolable virtue story about why I need to keep thinking and acting the way that I do. I don't really want to change my beliefs because my stories conveniently explain my feelings and feel so right. Based on the evidence of my outcomes, it would be reasonable to change how I think and behave, but I don't want to be reasonable! I don't want to use my creative faculties to manage the sources of my suffering because then I won't be able to defend my choices, and my “logic” will be exposed as foolishness. Of course, I am not wrong, and I will use my God-given creative ability to prove it! As one writer remarked, “Logic is the art of going wrong with confidence.”³

Skill versus competition for resources

Skills are abilities that we gain through training and experience, and suffering often motivates us to learn these skills. Sometimes, our suffering is connected to making mistakes. Mistakes are inevitable, but we can use our mistakes as opportunities to learn how to productively fall down and get up again. We also suffer when we encounter our weaknesses, and yet weaknesses provide excellent training ground for developing the skills we need to successfully navigate our lives in this material world. These hard-won skills are then available for managing all of life's difficulties, and we can offer wisdom to others who are suffering in similar ways.

I was given a mediocre education that did not train me to write clearly or well, and I suffered from trauma and poor health for decades. Now in the KF editing process, I am laboriously recruiting and prioritizing my health resources in order to learn the difficult skill of writing well. Once I have adequately learned this skill, I will be able to write other materials more easily and efficiently.

When we refuse to learn skills, we are unable to access the power that is ours to change our circumstances. Lack of skill invites discouragement and self-hate, and in that condition, we can only wait and fret until our suffering is magically resolved by a change in our situation, by someone else, or by God. By neglecting the development of practical skills, we abdicate authority over our own lives and allow our resources to be drained into habitual and unproductive patterns of thinking and behaving. These thoughts and behaviors compete for our resources because they conscript our real strengths to prop up our virtue stories and restore our pride system. For example, we might realize that we can't be in real relationships and, at the same time, make others do what we want. We may not, however, be willing to give up the satisfaction we feel when things go our way. This craving to control drains energy and diverts attention that could be invested in developing the skills we need to build healthy, productive relationships.

Excellent behavior versus compelling selfish ambition

Excellent behavior is a common theme throughout the Bible. In his letter to the Philippians, Paul offers a succinct list of healthy thought patterns that empower us to make the oriented choices that lead to excellent behavior:

“In all of your dealings take into account what is true, what is divinely noble, what is oriented and just, what is undefiled and pure, what is beloved, what imparts good omen. Notice if anything is excellent and commendable. ⁹And make it your business to practice these things.”⁴

This characteristic of wisdom cannot be fairly evaluated by our judgment alone. We are often too partial to our virtue stories, claims, and pride to admit that compelling selfish ambition is at the root of our choices and behavior. Selfish ambition is a kind of greed. It insists that our agenda comes first; life and others should accommodate us, and that judgment excuses our efforts to steal from others. Selfish ambition disconnects you from God and harms your community. When you are bulldozing a path toward idealized fulfillment, your behavior cannot be excellent; you will sacrifice your community to support your pride and to relieve your own anxiety and tension.

Using tools gently versus taking cheap, habitual short-cuts to relieve tension

I encourage all KF members to use their tools gently without forcing, traumatizing, or judging themselves. Learn to endure the tension of your suffering while you take small, slow, steady steps toward restoration. Suffering is an inevitable challenge in a messed-up world. God doesn't create your suffering, but He uses your environmental and internal suffering to train you to become a trustworthy heir in His kingdom. Keep your mind focused on that goal.

If you are less focused on finding relief from the mild form of suffering that KF training imposes and more focused on what you can learn in and through your experience, you will find the training less stressful. If, however, you value your pride system and its promise of effortless superiority more than you value your training, you will revert to your cheap, habitual shortcuts for managing suffering. There are as many shortcuts as there are people! What makes you feel alive, proud, right, bold, euphoric, in control, naughty, rebellious, valuable, numb? Whatever you do to achieve those feelings or maintain those beliefs about yourself are shortcuts to idealized glory. Try not to think of KF as a magic fix for all your problems but, rather, as a nursery where God can train you to manage your own life gently, compassionately, and carefully.

Holiness versus lost connection with Heaven

Holiness is a dwelling place. It is not something that we achieve from time to time, maybe on Sundays and

holidays; rather, it is a place or a quality of life set apart in which we dwell. If we are holy, we live like those set apart for a specific and divine purpose, and this holiness invites others into a deeper karis relationship with God. If, on the other hand, our lives, thoughts, and behavior do not reflect the culture of Christ's kingdom and the character of our God, we nullify the potential of our imputed holiness in Christ. The full potential of our holiness is not achieved by simply resting in the work of Jesus on the cross. It is achieved by co-laboring with God to make our lives a place of sanctuary where others can find the pure air, peace, and safety of holiness.

As our understanding and knowledge of God's holiness grows, we are increasingly motivated to choose holiness and preserve our connection with heaven. Holiness has to do with purity. As true saints who have been sanctified for a holy mission, we apprehend the monstrous horror of sin, evil, and pride. Although we can compassionately observe the destructive choices of others, we are no longer willing to tolerate the sin that contaminates our own lives. We actively pursue paths that will purify and defend our True Self from evil, trusting that the power of holiness will benefit everyone. This active pursuit is the *telos*, or fulfillment, of holiness, and it equips us to become "instruments of righteousness" in the world.⁵

When we act like animals, creeping around on the earth simply eating, sleeping, playing, maneuvering for our next sexual thrill, and mindlessly reacting to every perceived threat to our search for glory, we have lost connection with heaven. We are not oriented to God or to our intended role in the Creation. We are not holy because we are no longer connected to the source of holiness. God gave human beings the gift of dominion in this material world, and that dominion sets us apart from the rest of Creation. We are not simply animals; we are creatures uniquely designed to be holy, just as our Creator is holy, and our mission is to offer that holiness in this material world. We are created to feel at home with a holy God, and as we grow up in holiness, we become His trustworthy friends.

Mercy and compassion versus egocentricity

Mercy is the confident choice to offer gifts of grace and truth to another person. This virtue is similar to covering for someone, but it extends beyond simple kindness. Mercy is our active choice to withhold the punishment, consequences, or judgment that we think a person deserves for having done harm, for failing to live up to our standards, or for simply going about their business in a way that happens to obstruct our search for glory. Merciful people refuse to seek vengeance and vindictive triumph. When we are confident in our skills and confident in God's provision, we can afford to be merciful. God, in His mercy, offered Jesus as a karis gift, inviting everyone in this material world into karis relationship. This gift was a demonstration of God's character.⁶ When we become God's children, we learn to offer mercy, like He did, and with that gift we invite others into karis relationship.

Our inability to offer mercy to ourselves and to others is directly proportionate to the depth of our egocentricity. This egocentricity makes us very vulnerable; we are easily threatened and quick to take offense. Our Idol Self must continually defend itself against the reality of cause and effect, the choices of others, and life's common and inevitable events. In a frantic effort to avoid self-examination and a confrontation with the truth about ourselves, we blame others, circumstances, and God. We are not able to examine ourselves or offer mercy because, as egocentric neurotics, we really do believe that the judgments we are making are true and unbiased. Our logic about the wrongs done to us, how the past has crippled us, and what we could have been "if only . . ." seems indisputable. We believe our logic because, in our self-righteous omniscience, we have deemed our judgments to be the final word, and we are, therefore, not interested in the opinions of others, not even God's. We cannot afford to give up those judgments and beliefs because they support our pride, and we depend on the pride system to support a spurious sense of value and self-confidence in a very unreliable world.

Producing good outcomes versus producing disorder

It's not easy to recognize the difference between a good outcome and disorder when the compelling needs and values of the Idol Self are severely distorting our discernment. The Bible and experienced members of the community can help us recognize what is a good outcome. Peter asks us, "Do you want to see good days and live in loving relationships?" Do *you*? He then tells you how to get those good outcomes—"Turn away from evil and do good."⁷ You might ask yourself: Do my thoughts and choices have the quality of a generous long temper that leads to producing more of the Fruit of the Spirit in my life and in the lives of those around me; or are my thoughts and choices the product of a short temper, quick arrogant reactions, or an inability to endure opposition? Have I failed to see the beam in my own eye and refused to work on my own problem? Am I simply ignoring the evidence of pride in my life? If your choices reflect the pride side of the **Love or Pride?** list, whatever you do will produce disorder even though others may applaud or commend you. God must oppose you when you make choices out of pride, and disconnection from heaven cannot help but cause disorder in the Creation.

JOY

Do you remember learning from James that you can guide yourself into joy?⁸ God designed you to be joyful, even in the midst of your suffering, but you need training. When you experience suffering of any kind, you have an opportunity to train.

ACTION

You can now use KF integration tools to process what you have just learned in the worksheet and align yourself with *Wisdom from Above*. You might then follow the steps of **A-S-K** (Ask, Seek, Knock) or **WAA!** (Words, Attitude, Action) as you continue to seek the help that you need.⁹ You might also go back through this worksheet with someone who has more experience in KF training or with someone who loves you and knows you well. These actions are your karis gifts to God, and they demonstrate your willingness to cooperate with Him in your training.

Now that you have exercised your internal father by making the effort to fill out the worksheet, exercise your internal mother by showing yourself some compassion and care. Learn to maintain the balance of self-management and self-care in your suffering. Care for yourself while you face realities, and ask, seek, and knock for your solutions.

Let's review our quote from last week.

Research has shown that repeated action, learning, and memory can actually change the nervous system physically, altering both synaptic strength and connections. Such changes may be brought about by cultivated change in emotion and action; they will, in turn, change subsequent experience.¹⁰

We are cultivating these changes by practicing the tools of Karis Fellowships.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Spirit of truth, reveal the real source of my suffering. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Oh, blessed moment! After six months of KF training, we are now ready to embrace KF Confession 7:

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

Our inner conflicts and compelling needs force us into the wisdom, or cleverness, of taking cheap, habitual shortcuts that make us a target for demonic infiltration. In order to create outcomes of orientation, we must regularly think and act in ways that will promote calm and peace in our lives. Through prayer and meditation, mindfulness training, circulation, and the use of our KF tools, we are sowing seeds of oriented choices, which over time will produce a harvest of oriented outcomes. We will then have more and more access to the wisdom from above. The effort we make to plant these seeds is the cause that produces the glorious effect of a peaceful and fulfilled life—a life that flows out of a mature and fully equipped True Self.

We really do need to respect the reality of cause and effect. Whatever we do, whether oriented or misoriented, we plant seeds. Seeds determine the harvest, and a quality harvest begins with quality seed. The Bible tells us how to plant quality seed—seeds of orientation—which will produce the abundant harvest of an ever-developing and glorious life.

I am going to offer just two short passages, but I hope that you will go back and read these passages within their contexts.

A well-known passage about cause and effect is found in chapter 6 of Paul’s letter to the Galatians. This is my paraphrase of **Galatians 6:7–10**.

⁷Do not be influenced to wander and misorient. God is not to be outwitted or sneered at. This is how it works: whatever a person sows, that will they also reap. ⁸For the one who sows into the Idol Self (or the flesh), out of the Idol Self will reap deterioration and ruin; but the one who sows into the True Self (or the spirit), out of the True Self will reap an ever-developing life. ⁹Since this is so, do not be negligent in doing what is virtuous and beautiful. If we do not relax our effort, we will reap at the proper time and in due season. ¹⁰Therefore, when any opportunity presents itself to you, perform what is of benefit to all, but especially to the trustworthy community.

Take a deep breath.

When I was a young adult, I didn’t understand the principle of cause and effect. I thought that a bag of cookies was an adequate lunch, that time was something I could manipulate to accommodate my compulsive needs, and that my performance was unaffected by fatigue or lack of sleep. I thought that God controlled everything, so I allowed myself to be controlled by everything. I was egocentrically sowing into the Idol Self and expected the Harvest of the Spirit in return. I assumed that everyone, including God, would accommodate me.

In our passage from Galatians we can see that God supports the cause and effect process, but in our misorientation we don't want to believe that. We prefer to believe that if we put energy and resources into our cravings, judgments, and pride, we can still hope to get satisfying outcomes. Our pride system wastes an enormous amount of energy making judgments that generate self-hate, and we then expend more energy chasing perfection in a frantic attempt to maintain our pride and protect ourselves from a further onslaught of self-hate. We can choose to sow either judgment or love, and the reality is that we will reap whatever we sow, whether in our work, our relationships, our own health and development, or in our play. In KF, we are learning to sow our energy and resources into the ways of eternity, and as a result, our True Self is reaping eternal life from the Spirit of God. Eternal life constitutes all the glorious qualities of growth and orientation that can be experienced in this life and beyond. Even when we don't feel like it, we can choose life;¹¹ we can courageously do productive, orienting things and grow into our potential as spiritual creatures living in this material world.

Let's turn to our beloved letter from James. This is my translation of **James 5:7–11**.

⁷Therefore, be long-tempered my siblings, until the Lord presents Himself. Consider this: the farmer, being long-tempered, waits for the valuable and prized fruit of the earth until he receives the early and afternoon showers. ⁸You also, be long-tempered. Resolve to turn your hearts around because the presence of the Lord approaches. ⁹Siblings, do not groan in judgment against others or you yourself risk being judged. Look! The real Judge is standing at the door! ¹⁰My siblings, receive the example and illustration of the unmerited suffering and long temper of the prophets who spoke in the name of the Lord. ¹¹Look at it this way. Even we, in our immature state, congratulate those who endure. You have heard of the endurance of Job and have seen its outcome. Job's life is evidence that the Lord is vastly merciful and compassionate.

Take a deep breath.

We can practice being long-tempered rather than defaulting to being short-tempered, unwilling to endure adversity, or simply grouchy. The long fuse of endurance is not beyond the reach of any of us. We are all called to give up our childish short fuses and exercise self-control. It is out of this self-management that we can make oriented choices, creating a harmonious reality full of potential for ourselves and those around us. No matter how we feel, we can plant seeds of orientation, which later, in their season, will bear worthwhile and satisfying fruit.

You might think of the principle of cause and effect in this way: *"My life is what it is because . . ." Be your own cause. (Repeat)* You are the cause that generated the outcomes you have. You are a powerful creature, and your power can be directed toward generating different outcomes. Outcomes are not created by magic or luck; you create them. Begin generating new outcomes by first becoming the cause of your own orientation, and then see what happens. Take care of your business. Your business is to sow good seed, do good work, speak good thoughts, give good gifts, and then wait. Allow others time to take care of their business; and, especially, with humility allow God time to take care of His.

Our prayer might go something like this:

*Great Sower of the logos, show me where to sow good seeds that will produce an abundant harvest.
(Repeat)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water, and you might wish to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an area of your life, or a person, into which you can sow oriented seed. (Repeat) That person could be yourself. (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider an area where you might sow some oriented seed*, breathe and notice your feelings or the absence of feelings. Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. *(Pause)* Attend to whatever you are experiencing with compassion, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. As you *consider an area where you might sow some oriented seed*, observe and explore your experience without judgment. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing right now as you *consider sowing oriented seed into this area of your life or into another's life*. Observe your sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider the possibility of sowing oriented seed*. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider sowing this oriented seed? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of what might be possible or, perhaps, of what might be painful? Observe your experience as just information. You might process with a long exhaling breath, or the Dragon Breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore the causes of your life.
- Welcome the gentle Holy Counselor, who can show you where to sow.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.¹²

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- While sowing seeds of orientation, I let go of the longing for control and getting my own way.
- While sowing seeds of orientation, I let go of the longing for respect and admiration.
- While sowing seeds of orientation, I let go of the longing for survival and comfort.
- While sowing seeds of orientation, I let go of the longing for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time to heal and train together. Remind us that we are the cause of the quality of our own lives. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to become more effective and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

Pray for the members of Karis Fellowships, that God would help us plant seeds of time, talent, and finances to make possible a harvest of orientation in this world.

¹ *Spirit of God Descend Upon My Heart* by George Croly (1780–1860); www.youtube.com/watch?v=ymKxTkrRNBA.

² Heb. 10:31.

³ thinkexist.com/quotation/logic_is_the_art_of_going_wrong_with/176585.html.

⁴ Phil. 4:8–9.

⁵ Rom.6:13.

⁶ John 1:1–18.

⁷ 1 Peter 3:10–12.

⁸ James 1:2.

⁹ See KF16.

¹⁰ Maggie Macnab, *Decoding Design: Understanding and Using Symbols in Visual Communication* (How Books, 2008), 174.

¹¹ Deut. 30:19.

¹² www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.